of us ever take on in our lives. They bring the greatest pleasure and the greatest responsibility. I learned so much about both from my parents and from going through childhood in the home they made for me, Lynne and Joanne. That explains why my parents' splitting up has been probably the most difficult episode I've ever had to face up to in my whole life. To be honest, I'm still trying to face up to it now.

It's not for me to tell the story of how Mum and Dad's marriage ended in divorce. I can't tell my story, though, without talking about how my parents' splitting up has made me feel and still makes me feel. I've been through some difficult stuff in the course of my career and I think I've always been able to handle it. My life is my responsibility now and I've always reacted to challenges by taking them on. There's always a sense of needing to be in control and of trying to take charge of situations in a positive way. My parents' divorce, though, I haven't been able to deal with in that way at all. I was involved but what was happening was something completely outside my control. And that scared me, the first and only time I'd felt that way about what was going on around me. Over the couple of years when things were falling apart, I couldn't bring myself to talk about it. And talking to Mum and Dad was the thing I found hardest of all.

It may be that anyone who's been through the experience of parents' separating will recognize my emotions as the same ones they've had to struggle with. In a family like ours, your mum and dad and them being together is like the sun coming up in the morning. It's something for always. You can't ever imagine them apart, not even when you leave home and start life on your own. Probably the hardest thing to deal with has been thinking—or being made to think—that the split was somehow my fault. I remember the time and the energy they both put into me as a son and as a promising soccer player. Should they have given some of the attention they gave to me to each other instead?

Then, I'd never have thought about it. Did they? Now, when I think back, it's already too late to do anything about it.

However old you are when it happens, children in a divorce always find themselves feeling guilty. Or find themselves being made to feel guilty. I believe that what happens between husband and wife, deep down, is between husband and wife and nobody else; not even their sons and daughters can change the outcome. My dad's actually said to me that having my own family and not spending as much time with my parents was part of the problem for them. I did find myself wondering: would me going out with Dad, us talking,